George Orwell's 1984

Adapted by Robert Owens; Wilton Hall, Jr and William Miles, Jr.

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: *ACTOR – Winston, Syme*
ACTRESS – Loudspeaker, Messenger, Coffee Vendor, Guard, O'Brien, Julia, Big Brother's Voice, Goldstein's Voice

LOUDSPEAKER: **(Pg 10-11)** Attention! Our standard of living has risen 20 percent over the past year. Workers are parading through the streets with banners voicing their gratitude to Big Brother for the new, happy life which his wise leadership has bestowed upon us. All Hail Big Brother! All Love Big Brother! This morning three spies confessed to being members of the Goldstein Brotherhood of Traitors. This afternoon at 1700 hours they will be hanged in Victory Square. All Party members are invited to attend!

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Here's the thing: 2019 looks a lot like 1984*
ACTRESS: *And we're remarkably comfortable with it.*
ACTOR: *For starters, it's hard to ignore the similarities between Big Brother and Donald Trump who, for some, commands a similar unwavering fealty.*
ACTRESS: *Critics are comparing recent attacks on "fake news" to George Orwell's book 1984.*
ACTOR: *And I quote, "What you're seeing and what you're reading is not what's happening."*
ACTRESS: *In July of 2018, President Trump criticized the media and publicly announced that people should not believe what they see or what they read.*
ACTOR: *What's more, I can ask Siri to order a pizza, ask Google to play my favorite song or have Alexa turn on the air-conditioning.*
ACTRESS: *Yes, and with the power of facial-recognition, some fear that Big Brother can actually track you. Leading to California's recent ban on such technology.*
ACTOR: *It's 2019 . . . How much is 2 + 2 today?*
TOGETHER: *George Orwell's 1984 adapted by Robert Owens; Wilton Hall, Jr and William Miles, Jr.*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

(Pg 12-13) *[A messenger enters, carrying an armful of manila folders stuffed with papers]*

MESSENGER: Good morning. Big Brother has plenty for you to do today. *[To Syme]* Syme, this is for you. *[Hands over a folder]* You are told to have it translated into Newspeak no later than 1230 hours. *[To Winston, handing him a folder of papers]* And this is for you Smith. A whole month's work of malreports from the *Times*.

WINSTON: Thank you! *[As the Messenger turns to leave]* Wait! What about Withers? You forgot him.

MESSENGER: *[Turning back blankly]* Withers? I have nothing here for any Withers.

WINSTON: *[Pointing to a desk next to his]* This desk right here. The man who's been working with us – next to me – Withers.

MESSENGER: *[Shortly]* There's no such name on my route list. *[Exits]*

COFFEE VENDOR: **(Pg 15-17)** Victory Coffee. Victory Coffee. Get your coffee and praise the bounty of Big Brother. *[Winston groans as he get up and goes toward her]* Have you heard about the Two Minutes Hate this morning. I'm told it's something special Something plus good. . . Doubleplusgood.

WINSTON: *[wearily, to the Coffee Vendor]* What is the hate today?

COFFEE VENDOR: *[confidentially]* I hear it's going to be Goldstein himself. Isn't that exciting? I can hardly wait. . . Drink up. Next coffee period at 1100 hours. Get your refills then *[Exits]*

GUARD: *[Shouting]* Attention. Attention for a member of the Inner Party. He is Smith, sir. That one . . . number 6079. *[Guard exits. Winston jumps to attention behind his desk. O'Brien enters with Julia]*

O'BRIEN: Turn the screen down. I don't want any interruptions. You must remember that although you cannot hear it and can only see the picture of Big Brother, it can still both hear and see you. Many thought criminals have been trapped by that. This is Julia. She is to take the place of – the vacant place next to you. *[O'BRIEN exits]*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

JULIA: **(Pg 18-22)** *[Settles herself behind the desk; she doesn't know where to begin]* Whose place am I taking?

WINSTON: Bob Withers'. *[Angrily]* I mean, no one's place. You are taking no one's place. And unperson. Don't you understand an unperson. Aren't you familiar at all with Newspeak?

JULIA: A few words. Crimethink, duckspeak, goodthink Mini-true, I know means the Ministry of Truth. Proles means the workers, the proletarian – they aren't really human Child-hero means a child who is a member of the children's Spies organization who has turned in one of his own family for thought-crime But . . . but I've never heard of an unperson.

WINSTON: *[exasperated]* I'll ask Syme, the expert, to explain Newspeak to you. In the meantime, here is a Newspeak dictionary. In it are all Oldspeak words – what we used to call STANDARD English – translated into Newspeak. An unperson is a person who's been vaporized – hanged – killed. He no longer exists.

JULIA: Oh! Vaporized. Of course . . . but, he did exist at one time.

WINSTON: *[practically yelling]* He never existed. That's your job here. Look here! In the March 17, 1982 edition of the Times, Bob Withers was awarded the goodworker medal. So we choose the name of another worker in the Ministry of Truth on March 17, 1982. Any name. Ad send it to the Times with the correction. That issue is re-run with the corrected name, and all old editions of that issue are destroyed. We toss this message in the incinerator . . . destroy it! Then – there is no record any place on earth that Bob Withers ever existed.

JULIA: But you know he existed.

WINSTON: *[warily, certain she is trying to trap him into a speak-crime]* I do not know he existed. *[Patiently]* You know the word double-think? *[Julia nods]* You must use doublethink. Every good loyal Party member is capable of doublethink. You know the

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Party slogan: "Who controls the past – controls the future. Who controls the present controls the past."

JULIA: I didn't know it had meaning. I thought it just didn't mean anything . . . like the other slogans: War is Peace . . . . Freedom is Slavery . . . Ignorance is Strength.

WINSTON: Of course it has a meaning. It's our job here in the Ministry of Truth to carry out that slogan. *[His voice grows louder as he loses control]* To control the past!

LOUDSPEAKER: Attention! Attention for the Two Minutes Hate. The Two Minutes Hate is about to begin. Stand by for a message from our devoted leader, Big Brother.

BIG BROTHER'S VOICE: *[harsh, grating unpleasant]* Repeat:

TOGETHER: War is Peace! Freedom is Slavery! Ignorance is Strength!

BIG BROTHER' VOICE: In a moment you will hear the despised Goldstein, whose shadowy army conspires to destroy our new happy life. Listen to his lies . . . then show him what you think.

GOLDSTEIN'S VOICE: *[Quiet, undistinguished voice. At every pause there Winston cries "Liar!" "Swine!" "Criminal!" "Traitor!"]* Friends . . . I am Emmanuel Goldstein Your ex leader and still your friend. I am still fighting for your liberty, your freedom, your hope. Big Brother has usurped power. He is a ruthless tyrant. He lies. He talks of a new happy life while he starves your bodies and denies your souls . . .

WINSTON: Traitor! Liar! Spy!

GOLDSTEIN'S VOICE: Remember that all men are created equal, and endowed by their Creator with certain inalienable rights . . . that among these are life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness. Fee yourselves. Down with Big Brother! *[Broadcast ends amid Boos and hisses from Winston and everyone returns to work]*

WINSTON: **(Pg 25-28)** Syme . . . . This is Julia. She has been in the fiction department of Minitrue and they still use Standard English there. Here of course, she must understand Newspeak. She doesn't. *[Winston exits and assumes the persona of Syme who instructs Julia]*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

JULIA: It must be a lot of work inventing new words.

SYME: We don't invent words – we destroy them . . . scores of them . . . every day. We're cutting language down to the bone.

JULIA: *[in wonder]* Do you really destroy words?

SYME: Indeed yes. A beautiful thing – the destruction of words. Absolutely the best way to control thought. What justification is there for a word that is the opposite of some other word?

JULIE: Well, you must . . . I mean – well, take a word like "good"

SYME: All right. What need is there for a word like "bad"? "Ungood" will do just as well.

JULIE: *[Interested]* How about "better" and "best?" Good . . . better . . . beat!

SYME: We simply say: plus good or doubleplus good. Simple isn't it? Of course, it was Big Brother's idea originally.

JULIA: You make it sound as though the language will eventually b cut to where it will be difficult to think at all.

SYME: Exactly! We will defeat Goldstein that way. Newspeak is the only language whose vocabulary gets smaller ever year. The whole aim of Newspeak is to narrow the range of thought.

JULIA: But how does that stop Goldstein or – or have any effect on thought-crime?

SYME: *[patiently]* Why, because in the end it will make thought-crime literally ipossible, for there will be no words to express it. For instance, take that gibberish of Goldstein's about "all men being created equal," That would be impossible to render into Newspeak The closest you could come would be the one word: crime-think. By 2050 – when everyone speaks nothing but Newspeak – not a single human being alive would understand the conversation we are now having. All real knowledge of Oldspeak will be destroyed. Even literature. Chaucer, Shakespeare, Milton All will exist only in Newspeak. *[Proudly]* I'm working on that now. Orthodoxy! Orthodoxy means not

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

thinking – not needing to think. *[Syme hand her a huge dictionary]* Read it . . . and call on me for any explanations. *[Syme exits]*

WINSTON: Now do you understand Newspeak?

JULIA: *[very confused]* Yes . . I mean no! I understand the words; [but] the why? I don't understand the why! I should never have been given this job. Nothing adds up. I . . . I'm . . . it's like saying that two plus two make five.

WINSTON: And if two plus two do make five?

JULIA: *[near tears]* Do you believe that?

WINSTON: *[suddenly all his hate and anger spilling out]* You want me to commit a thought-crime, don't you? A speak-crime – so you can report me. Do you think I'm a complete fool? *[regaining his composure, he speaks softly]* **(Pg 35-36)** The past has been abolished Every record has been destroyed or altered . . . every book rewritten. Already we know nothing about the years before the Revolution. I help falsify the past. It will mean the final loss of freedom.

JULIA: Freedom, freedom. What is freedom, Winston? Maybe the Party is right . . . maybe freedom is slavery.

WINSTON: *[sharply]* No! *[Thinks a moment]* Freedom is the freedom to say two plus tow is four.

LOUDSPEAKER: **(Pg 39)** How can you tell a thought-criminal? Look carefully at the ones you suspect. Do they look unlovingly at Big Brother? Yes, face-crime is thoughtcrime. Report these agents of Goldstein's to your nearest Thought Police. The Thought Police helicopter will be there immediately. *[Winston's face breaks into a big grin]* Repeat after me, Smith. Two plus two is five. Two plus two is five . . . . *[continues to repeat]*

WINSTON: **(Pg 74)** *[overlapping the second sentence softly at first but growing louder and more defiant]* Two plus two is four . . . . is four . . . is four . . . is four *[He shakes his fists in*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

the direction of the voice and screams] Two plus two is four! It's four . . . it's four. Four . . . . **(Pg 66)** *[A Guard stamps into the room and drags Winston away]*

LOUDSPEAKER: (Pg 21) War is Peace!

WINSTON: (Pg 71) No!

LOUDSPEAKER: (Pg 21) Freedom is Slavery!

WINSTON: (Pg 71) NO!

LOUDSPEAKER: (Pg 21) Ignorance is Strength!

WINSTON: (Pg 74) *[Defiantly]* Two plus two is four!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Adapted by: Robert Owens; Wilton Hall, Jr and William Miles, Jr.
ISBN: 978-0871295422
Publisher: Dramatic Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Sept 1963

AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2018 National Qualifier
FL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY